

Checklist

Stakeholder Relationship Management

1. Map Your Stakeholders

- ☐ Identify the stakeholders who can materially affect your team's success.
- ☐ Assess each stakeholder's **power** within the organization.
- ☐ Assess each stakeholder's **interest** in your team or platform.
- ☐ Place stakeholders on a power-interest grid:
 - ☐ **High power / high interest:** Manage closely.
 - ☐ **High power / low interest:** Keep satisfied.
 - ☐ **Low power / high interest:** Keep informed.
 - ☐ **Low power / low interest:** Monitor with minimum effort.
- ☐ Identify who has the ear of the most senior leadership.
- ☐ Determine which teams are considered indispensable versus "nice to have."
- ☐ Identify the loudest and most respected stakeholder groups.
- ☐ Consider how much it would matter if a stakeholder strongly disliked your team.
- ☐ Revisit the map as organizational priorities and relationships change.

2. Prioritize Relationship-Building

- ☐ Spend the most relationship-management time on **high-power, high-interest** stakeholders.
- ☐ Build relationships before a crisis or escalation occurs.
- ☐ Understand each stakeholder's goals, pressures, incentives, and concerns.
- ☐ Treat stakeholder disagreements as differences in perspective rather than automatically as "politics."
- ☐ Remember that stakeholders may be optimizing for a different part of the business.
- ☐ Look for patterns across stakeholder complaints instead of reacting to every complaint individually.

3. Communicate With the Right Level of Transparency

- ☐ Decide the main message you want stakeholders to take away before communicating.
- ☐ Lead with outcomes, impact, risks, decisions, and next steps.
- ☐ Avoid overwhelming stakeholders with unnecessary technical or operational detail.
- ☐ Provide additional detail when a stakeholder specifically asks for it.
- ☐ Adjust the level of technical detail to the audience.
- ☐ Avoid inviting stakeholders to micromanage your team's day-to-day work.
- ☐ Avoid sending so much information that important signals get lost.
- ☐ Do not rely on engineering detail alone to resolve relationship or trust problems.
- ☐ Make business impact visible rather than assuming stakeholders understand it.

4. Use 1:1 Meetings Deliberately

- ☐ Use early 1:1s to understand stakeholders' concerns, power, interest, and motivations.
- ☐ Use regular 1:1s primarily with your most important stakeholders.
- ☐ Avoid creating a meeting cadence that cannot scale.
- ☐ Reduce unnecessary 1:1s when the relationship is healthy and little discussion is needed.
- ☐ Consider roughly monthly 1:1s for "manage closely" stakeholders.
- ☐ Consider roughly quarterly 1:1s for "keep satisfied" or "keep informed" stakeholders.
- ☐ Use private conversations for sensitive issues rather than relying solely on broad updates.

5. Track Expectations and Commitments

- ☐ Take private notes after stakeholder conversations.
- ☐ Record what you agreed to investigate, deliver, or follow up on.
- ☐ Record dates or expected timelines where relevant.
- ☐ Send a short written follow-up when an agreement could be misunderstood.
- ☐ Give stakeholders the opportunity to correct your understanding.
- ☐ Review outstanding commitments regularly.
- ☐ Close the loop when work is completed, delayed, or changed.
- ☐ Avoid making promises that are not captured anywhere.

6. Run Effective Interlock Meetings or Advisory Boards

- ☐ Establish a regular forum for multiple stakeholders when individual 1:1s no longer scale.
- ☐ Determine the desired outcome for each meeting.
- ☐ Decide what information and decisions will be presented.
- ☐ Decide where stakeholder input is actually needed.
- ☐ Structure the meeting so stakeholders can participate without letting it devolve into an unbounded debate.
- ☐ Prepare the appropriate product, engineering, and operational owners.
- ☐ Use product leaders for roadmap and feature discussions.
- ☐ Include engineering leaders when operational or delivery matters require technical context.
- ☐ Surface disagreements between stakeholders where useful so your team is not caught between contradictory demands.
- ☐ Capture decisions, commitments, owners, and next steps.

7. Adjust Communication During Rough Patches

- ☐ Keep communication lightweight when the platform is stable and stakeholders are satisfied.
- ☐ Increase communication when reliability, delivery, cost, or confidence deteriorates.
- ☐ Explain what is happening without hiding significant problems.
- ☐ State what is being done about the issue.
- ☐ Clarify owners, timelines, risks, and expected next updates.
- ☐ Supplement meetings with written updates when the situation changes quickly.
- ☐ Continue increased communication until the rough patch has genuinely passed.

8. Handle Disagreements and Requests

- ☐ Make sure you understand the stakeholder's underlying business need.
- ☐ Gather enough information to understand the business impact.
- ☐ Avoid assuming your existing roadmap is automatically correct.
- ☐ Evaluate the value of current work against the stakeholder's request.
- ☐ Explain trade-offs in terms of business impact rather than internal preferences.
- ☐ Look for compromises involving scope, timing, ownership, or sequencing.

- ☐ Escalate, when necessary, to individuals with broader organizational responsibility.
- ☐ Avoid treating every disagreement as something that must have a single “right” answer.

9. Say “Yes, With Compromises” When Appropriate

- ☐ Consider accommodating high-value requests that require little sacrifice.
- ☐ Look for a smaller first version that solves the most important need.
- ☐ Limit the scope rather than automatically rejecting the entire request.
- ☐ Negotiate timing if immediate delivery is unrealistic.
- ☐ Consider whether the requesting team can contribute engineering effort.
- ☐ Be explicit about what is and is not included.
- ☐ Explain the impact of reprioritization to other affected stakeholders.
- ☐ Avoid becoming a feature factory that says yes to everything.

10. Say “No” Without Damaging the Relationship

- ☐ Determine whether the answer is truly **no** or merely **not yet**.
- ☐ If it is “not yet,” explain what must happen before the request can be prioritized.
- ☐ Offer a realistic future point for reconsideration where possible.
- ☐ If the blocker is technical, explain the technical constraint in understandable terms.
- ☐ If the request conflicts with product strategy, explain the platform’s core mission and boundaries.
- ☐ If the request is technically infeasible, say so clearly rather than pretending it is simply a prioritization issue.
- ☐ Suggest alternatives, workarounds, or another appropriate system where possible.
- ☐ Keep the conversation focused on the problem rather than on ego or who is “right.”
- ☐ Ask your manager or another leader for help if you lack the authority to give a firm no.

11. Manage Shadow Platforms Constructively

- ☐ Identify why another team wants to build its own solution.

- ☐ Determine whether the driver is urgency, novel demand, poor collaboration, disagreement over operating costs, or engineers simply wanting to build.
- ☐ Address “us versus them” dynamics early.
- ☐ Build relationships with teams before they begin creating competing systems.
- ☐ Partner with teams when they have a legitimate, urgent need your platform cannot yet satisfy.
- ☐ Learn from novel solutions rather than automatically trying to stop them.
- ☐ Set clear expectations about long-term ownership and support.
- ☐ Decide whether successful innovations should later be absorbed into the platform.
- ☐ Accept that occasionally your team may need to clean up or operationalize a useful solution built elsewhere.

12. Prepare for Budget and Cost Pressure

- ☐ Assume that roadmaps alone will not justify your team during a downturn.
- ☐ Connect platform work directly to protected business outcomes.
- ☐ Identify which customers or initiatives will benefit from each major project.
- ☐ Review work outside essential operational or “keep the lights on” responsibilities.
- ☐ Pause speculative projects that are early, unclear, or expensive.
- ☐ Shrink projects when part of the investment can still deliver meaningful value.
- ☐ Build a clear business case for projects you strongly believe should continue.
- ☐ Seek senior sponsorship for important initiatives where appropriate.

13. Organize Work for Budget Discussions

- ☐ Group work into meaningful project teams rather than presenting person-by-person activities.
- ☐ Use team-sized chunks that leadership can understand and evaluate.
- ☐ Avoid creating a false impression of precision about individual utilization.
- ☐ Identify whole initiatives that could be reduced, delayed, or removed.
- ☐ Protect the teams and work that contribute most directly to critical outcomes.

14. Arrive With Your Own Cost-Cutting Proposal

- ☐ Decide in advance what you believe could reasonably be reduced or eliminated.
- ☐ Base recommendations on customer feedback, stakeholder input, business value, and operational necessity.

- ☐ Be prepared to defend the work you believe is essential.
- ☐ Avoid defending every project equally.
- ☐ Show that you understand the seriousness of the financial situation.
- ☐ Offer concrete trade-offs rather than waiting for executives to choose cuts for you.
- ☐ Use established stakeholder trust to influence where cuts are made.

15. Final Relationship Health Check

- ☐ Do stakeholders understand what your team does and why it matters?
- ☐ Do your most powerful stakeholders trust your judgment?
- ☐ Can you identify what each important stakeholder cares about?
- ☐ Are commitments documented and followed through?
- ☐ Are important disagreements surfaced early?
- ☐ Are communication channels appropriate for each stakeholder group?
- ☐ Can you say “no” without creating unnecessary hostility?
- ☐ Can you make reasonable compromises without losing sight of the platform strategy?
- ☐ Are you communicating more actively when circumstances deteriorate?
- ☐ Can you explain your team’s value in business terms?
- ☐ Do you already know what you would protect, reduce, or stop if budgets tightened?
- ☐ Are your stakeholder relationships strong enough to survive a difficult quarter?